

Adoption

doc-adoption

Soteriology · Adoption · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across many Bible texts

Subject named directly in Scripture

Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

By adoption, those justified are received into the family of God, granted the privileges, name, and inheritance of sons through union with Christ and indwelling of the Spirit of adoption.

In plain language

The proposition says that those who are justified (declared righteous by God) are received into the family of God and given the privileges, name, and inheritance of sons through union with Christ and the indwelling Spirit. The Greek text supports this strongly. The technical word for adoption, 'adoption as a son' (huiiothesia), was a real legal term in the Greek world meaning 'to place someone as a son', and the lexicons (Greek dictionaries) gloss it as 'adoption as a son'. When this word is searched across the whole Bible it appears exactly five times, all in Paul, at Romans 8 verse 15, Romans 8 verse 23, Romans 9 verse 4, Galatians 4 verse 5, and Ephesians 1 verse 5. In each place it means a conferred (granted, not earned) standing, not natural birth. Romans 8 contrasts a 'spirit of slavery' with the 'spirit of adoption' by which believers cry 'Father' (Abba), then says that if we are children we are heirs of God and joint heirs with Christ. Galatians 4 says the Son was sent to redeem (buy out of slavery) those under the law so that we might receive adoption, and Ephesians 1 grounds the same adoption in God's purpose through Christ. Supporting words confirm the picture: 'son' (huios) and 'child' (teknon) for the new family member, 'heir' (kleronomos) and 'joint heir' (sygkleronomos) for the inheritance, the 'Father' (Abba) cry for a real felt relationship, and 'redeem' (exagorazo) for the price that made it possible. There are two honest nuances that explain why careful readers still debate the edges. First, the very same word is a present possession in Romans 8 verse 15 yet a future hope in Romans 8 verse 23, the redemption of the body, which is an already-and-not-yet pattern (granted now, completed later) rather than two adoptions. Second, John and 1 John speak of being children of God using a birth word, 'born of God' (gennao), rather than the legal adoption word, so two pictures, being begotten and being legally placed, point to one conferred standing. The word is found only in Paul, so the technical witness is concentrated rather than pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible), but no text pulls against the reading. The lexical pattern affirms the proposition.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0005	ἄββᾶ	abba	Abba	3
G1080	γεννάω	gennao	to beget	97
G1397	δουλεία	douleia	slavery	5
G1401	δοῦλος	doulos	slave	130
G1805	ἐξαγοράζω	exagorazo	to redeem	4

G2818	κληρονόμος	kleronomos	heir	15
G2983	λαμβάνω	lambano	to take	264
G3962	πατήρ	pater	father	418
G4789	συγκληρονόμος	sygkleronomos	co-heir	4
G5043	τέκνον	teknon	child	99
G5206	υιοθεσία	huiiothesia	adoption (as son)	5
G5207	υιός	huios	son	380

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

The technical noun 'adoption as a son' (huiiothesia), G5206, is a deliberate Greco-Roman legal term meaning 'placing as a son', attested in extra-biblical inscriptions and built on the classical phrase 'to place as son'. Queried against the canon it occurs exactly five times, all in Paul: Romans 8:15, Romans 8:23, Romans 9:4, Galatians 4:5, and Ephesians 1:5, and in every instance it denotes conferred filial (son-related) status, not natural birth. Galatians 4:5 makes adoption the stated goal of the Son's redeeming mission. Romans 8:15-17 binds it to the indwelling Spirit who cries 'Father' (Abba) and to 'joint heirship' with Christ, 'fellow heir' (sygkleronomos) G4789. Ephesians 1:5 grounds it in God's predestining purpose through Christ. The slave-to-son-to-heir chain, 'slave' (doulos) G1401 to 'son' (huios) G5207 to 'heir' (kleronomos) G2818, and the Johannine 'right to become children of God', 'children of God' (tekna theou) G5043, in John 1:12 and 1 John 3:1, converge on the same conferred standing. The honest limit is that the technical term sits only in the Pauline corpus (Paul's letters), so the witness is concentrated rather than pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible).

Scripture

Rom.8.14 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5207 υιός

Reasoning. Those led by the Spirit of God, these are 'sons of God' (huiioi theou), G5207. The verse opens the adoption passage by defining the family by Spirit leading rather than natural descent, framing the conferred sonship (granted son-status) the proposition asserts.

Rom.8.15 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5206 υιοθεσία, G0005 ἀββά, G1397 δουλεία

Reasoning. Believers did not receive a 'spirit of slavery' ('slavery' = douleia, G1397) leading back to fear, but received a spirit of 'adoption as a son' (huiiothesia), G5206, in which they cry 'Father' (Abba), G0005. The contrast between slavery and adopted sonship is explicit, and the 'Father' (Abba) cry is the present relational evidence of the conferred status. Here adoption is spoken of as already received.

Rom.8.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5043 τέκνον

Reasoning. The Spirit bears joint witness with the human spirit that we are 'children of God' (tekna theou), G5043. This grounds the assurance of the adopted family relationship in the Spirit, matching the indwelling of the Spirit of adoption in the proposition.

Rom.8.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2818 κληρονόμος, G4789 συγκληρονόμος, G5043 τέκνον

Reasoning. If 'children' (tekna), G5043, then 'heirs' (kleronomoi), G2818, heirs of God and 'joint heirs' (sygkleronomoi), G4789, with Christ. The inheritance and the union with Christ named in the proposition are stated here as direct consequences of the child status, and the compound 'joint heir' term ties the inheritance to Christ.

Rom.8.23 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5206 υιοθεσία

Reasoning. Those who have the firstfruits of the Spirit groan within themselves awaiting the 'adoption as a son' (huiiothesia), G5206, the redemption of the body. The same term used for a present possession in Romans 8:15 is here the object of future hope, which exposes an already-and-not-yet structure (something both granted now and still to be completed later) rather than two adoptions.

Rom.9.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5206 υιοθεσία

Reasoning. To the Israelites belong the 'adoption as a son' (huiiothesia), G5206, and the glory and the covenants. The same legal 'placing as son' term is applied to corporate Israel (the nation as a whole), showing the word can carry a covenant national sense as well as the individual believer sense, but in both cases it denotes conferred filial (son-related) standing, not natural generation (physical birth).

Gal.4.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5206 υιοθεσία, G1805 εξαγοράζω

Reasoning. The purpose clause states that the sent Son 'redeems' ('redeem' = exagorase, G1805, meaning to buy out of slavery) those under law so that we might receive the 'adoption as a son' (huiiothesia), G5206. Adoption is the stated goal of the redemptive mission, and receiving it depends on the work of the sent Son, which supports the union with Christ basis in the proposition.

Gal.4.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5207 υιός, G0005 ἀββά

Reasoning. Because you are 'sons' (huioi), G5207, God sent forth the Spirit of his Son into our hearts crying 'Father' (Abba), G0005. The indwelling Spirit of the Son is the agent of the adopted relationship, matching the indwelling of the Spirit of adoption in the proposition.

Gal.4.7 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5207 υιός, G2818 κληρονόμος, G1401 δοῦλος

Reasoning. So you are no longer a 'slave' (doulos), G1401, but a 'son' (huios), G5207, and if a son then an 'heir' (kleronomos), G2818, through God. The transition from slave to son to heir summarizes the privileges and inheritance the proposition assigns to adoption.

Eph.1.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5206 υιοθεσία

Reasoning. He predestined us to 'adoption as a son' (huiiothesia), G5206, through Jesus Christ to himself. Adoption is grounded in the divine purpose and is routed through Christ, supporting the union with Christ clause of the proposition.

John.1.12 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G5043 τέκνον, G2983 λαμβάνω

Reasoning. To as many as 'received' ('received' = elabon, G2983) him he gave the right to become 'children of God' (tekna theou), G5043, to those believing on his name. The conferral of the standing of children of God to those who receive Christ supports the name and family privileges of the proposition, using a birth idiom (figure of speech about being born) rather than the legal term 'adoption as a son' (huiiothesia).

1John.3.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5043 τέκνον, G3962 πατήρ

Reasoning. See what love the 'Father' (pater), G3962, has given us that we should be called 'children of God' (tekna theou), G5043, and so we are. The Father confers the name of children, confirming the family relationship and the granted name in the proposition.

1John.3.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5043 τέκνον

Reasoning. Now we are 'children of God' (tekna theou), G5043, and what we will be has not yet appeared, but we know that when he appears we shall be like him. The present possession with a future unveiling parallels the already-and-not-yet pattern (granted now, completed later) of 'adoption as a son' (huiiothesia) in Romans 8 and supports the inheritance and glorification (final transformation into glory) dimension.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Rom.8.15	Rom.8.16	tsk	1
Rom.8.15	Mark.14.36	tsk	1
Gal.4.7	Gal.3.29	tsk	1
Gal.4.7	Gen.15.1	tsk	1
John.1.12	Isa.56.5	tsk	1
1John.3.1	1John.4.9	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Rom.8.23 · addressed

The same word 'adoption as a son' (huiiothesia) is a present possession in Romans 8:15 yet a future hope in Romans 8:23, the redemption of the body. This is not a contradiction but an already-and-not-yet structure (the status is granted now and finished later), the status is conferred now and consummated at bodily resurrection, so the proposition stands and the tension is internal to the one adoption.

Rom.9.4 · addressed

'Adoption as a son' (huiiothesia) is applied to corporate Israel (the nation as a whole) here, showing the term can carry a covenant national sense distinct from the individual believer sense in Romans 8 and Galatians 4. Both senses denote conferred filial (son-related) standing rather than natural generation (physical birth), so the word's range does not undercut the believer adoption the proposition asserts, it confirms the legal 'placing as son' meaning across both referents (the two groups it points to).

John.1.12 · addressed

John uses 'children' (tekna) with the birth idiom (figure of speech about being born), 'born of God' ('they were born' = egennethesan, G1080), in John 1:13 rather than the Pauline (Paul's) legal term 'adoption as a son' (huiiothesia). The lexicon (Greek dictionary) links 'child' (teknon) to begetting (the act of fathering a child) and 'adoption as a son' (huiiothesia) to legal placement, so these are two metaphors (word pictures), generation (being born) and adoption, that converge on the same conferred child status. The text therefore supports rather than complicates the proposition.

Concordance traversed

G5206, G5207, G5043, G2818, G4789, G0005, G1805, G3962, G2983, G1401, G1397, G1080

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

The anchor verses lie in Romans, Galatians, Ephesians, and the Johannine corpus (John's writings), all outside the open-cbqm 3 John sample, so this is ECM (Editio Critica Maior, the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) shadow rather than ECM published. The Greek text of Galatians 4:7 carries a known reading split between 'heir through God' and 'heir of God through Christ', but in every reading the slave-to-son-to-heir progression and the conferred sonship hold, so the verdict is variant robust (steady across textual variations).

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, dispensationalism

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

covenant_theology: affirms · Reads the Israel adoption of Romans 9:4 and the believer adoption of Romans 8 and Galatians 4 as one continuous covenantal sonship, so 'adoption as a son' (huiiothesia) is the realization of promised family standing and the proposition is affirmed.

dispensationalism: affirms · Distinguishes the corporate Israel adoption of Romans 9:4 from the present positional adoption of the believer in the Son in Romans 8 and Galatians 4, yet still affirms the believer's conferred sonship, inheritance, and name, so the proposition is affirmed.

already_not_yet_eschatology: affirms · Takes the single word 'adoption as a son' (huiiothesia) used as present possession in Romans 8:15 and future hope in Romans 8:23 as one adoption with two moments, legally granted now and bodily consummated (completed in the body) at resurrection, so the proposition is affirmed with its inheritance dimension intact.

All three readings converge on affirms because the verdict turns on the lexical (word-level) force of 'adoption as a son' (huiiothesia) and the slave-to-son-to-heir progression. The genuine divergence among them is the SCOPE and TIMING of adoption, whether the Israel sense and the believer sense are one line or two, and how the present and future uses of the one word relate, not whether the believer is adopted.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The proposition uses the canonical term 'adoption', 'adoption as a son' (huiiothesia), and standard family, name, and inheritance vocabulary without smuggling a tradition-specific verdict. The phrase 'Spirit of adoption' is itself the wording of Romans 8:15, so it is text-derived rather than preloaded. No neutralization needed.

Citations

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lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5206

lexicon	STEPBible-TFLSJ	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5206
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morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Gal.4.5
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Eph.1.5
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rom.8.15

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